PSC 3192W. Infrastructure: Inaction, & Inequality

Michael Hankinson
Assistant Professor
Department of Political Science
hankinson@gwu.edu

Lecture: T, 12:45-3:15 pm, PHIL 510
Office Hours: T, 3:30-5:00 pm, Monroe Hall 472

Semester Fall 2026

Course Description

How should we decide where to put things society needs, but few people want nearby?

In this seminar, we will focus on the political challenge of infrastructure in the United States. Infrastructure is broadly defined, but we will focus primarily on the supply of housing (market-rate and affordable) and clean energy infrastructure. Extensions will be made to other land uses from waste facilities, to transportation, to data centers. The political challenge at hand is how to provide infrastructure but also ensuring equity in its distribution of costs and benefits. Having considered normative goals, we will review the political hurdles to its provision, from the behavior of political actors to the institutional designs which create challenges.

As a writing in the discipline (WID) course, you will develop your own research paper on the supply–equity trade-off behind a specific piece of infrastructure. You will develop this paper throughout the course, incorporating peer feedback, and defend in it an oral exam.

Finally, I would like to thank the following colleagues for inspiration behind this course design: Janet Lewis, Robert Betz, David Szakonyi, Danny Hayes, Julian Wamble, and Henry Watson.

Learning Goals

The goal of this course is to improve your ability to:

1. Identify and evaluate competing theories about the role of government in constructing infrastructure;
2. Engage in thoughtful discussions about the various ways to ensure equitable outcomes;
3. Select valuable research questions and put forward designs to answer them;
4. Develop skills of presenting and defending research;
5. Craft original arguments and write polished papers in political science.

Course Prerequisites

PSC 1002. Introduction to American Politics and Government.

Expected Time Commitment

You will spend 2.5 hours per week in direct instruction or guided interaction. The average minimum amount of out-class learning expected per week is 8 hours (`https://cte.rice.edu/workload`) for a total of 120 hours per semester.

Readings

The only book we will be reading is *Why Nothing Works* (Marc J. Dunkelman 2025). You should acquire a copy as soon as possible via the vendor of your choice. All other readings will be posted on Blackboard.

"Supplemental Readings" are things I find interesting but are not necessary for the week's class. Readings are subject to change up to one week before their assigned class. I will tell you in class of any updates to the readings, but outside of the Dunkelman book, the material in the folder will always be accurate

Office Hours

I will hold office hours from 3:30 pm to 5:00 pm every Tuesday in my office, Monroe Hall 472. You are welcome to come by at any time during that window. However, I recommend that you email me in advance so I can reserve a time slot for you. If you arrive without emailing me in advance, you may have to wait for an available time slot to open.

Course Assignments and Grading

Grades will be composed of the following:

25% Participation
5% Paper proposal
10% Peer review comments
15% First submission
20% Second submission (grade will be capped based on your oral defense score)
25% Oral defense

At the end of the semester, your grade will be assigned based on the following scale: A (93-100), A- (90-92), B+ (87-89), B (83-86), B- (80-82), C+ (77-79), C (73-76), C- (70-72), D+ (67-69), D (63-66), D- (60-62), and F (0-59). Scores within one-half point of the next letter grade will be rounded up. While a curve may be used in determining the final distribution of grades, the curve will only be used to improve your grade.

All assignments are penalized by 1/3 a letter grade per day late, with the first day's penalty taking effect immediately after the deadline. I do not allow students to submit extra work in an attempt to raise their grade.

Participation

Students are expected to come to class prepared, having read and thought deeply about the readings for the week. **There will be cold-calling during the class.** Absences, tardiness, and low effort participation will negatively affect your participation grade.

Laptops and other electronic devices are not permitted in class. Please speak to me if you require a device for DSS accommodations.

Research Paper

In this assignment, you will write a research paper on the politics of infrastructure and the tension between inaction and inequality using a real dataset of siting outcomes. These papers will be approximately 20 pages double-spaced excluding bibliography.

1. Paper proposal ∼3 pages double-spaced (due 9/29, 11:59 pm)
2. First submission (due 10/26, 11:59 pm)
3. Peer review (due 11/2)
    - Each student will lead peer review comments for one of the papers
    - Remainder of students will comment during ∼20 minutes per paper
4. Second submission is (due 12/9, 11:59 pm)
5. An ∼15 minute oral defense will be scheduled during finals week.

Absence Policy

Absences will result in "zero" grades for participation and any activity that day. To account for mild illness, I drop the 2 lowest participation grades. For severe illness, absence will excused given medical documentation. For religious holidays or GW-required events, as per university policy, students must notify the professor during the first week of the semester about any class session that will be missed.

Important Dates

- 9/29 - Paper proposal due
- 10/26 - First submission
- 12/9 - Second submission
- TBD - Oral defense

Course Calendar

Readings

1. 8/25 Introduction
    (a) What preferences exist around infrastructure? How do those preferences vary across geography?
    (b) Why is building things difficult? What are the formal and informal ways that infrastructure is blocked?
    (c) What values constrain our options for solving this problem?

    - Syllabus
    - Roth, Sammy. 2022. "This power line could save California — and forever change the American West." *Los Angeles Times*.
    - Brouwer, Nick R., and Jessica Trounstine. 2024. "NIMBYs, YIMBYs, and the Politics of Land Use in American Cities." *Annual Review of Political Science* 27: 165–184.

    Supplemental reading

- Susskind, Lawrence, Jungwoo Chun, Alexander Grant, Chelsea Hodgkins, Jessica Cohen, and Sara Lohmar., 2022. "Sources of Opposition to Renewable Energy Projects in the United States." *Energy Policy* 165: 112922.
- Gelles, David. 2025. "A Power Line for Clean Energy Was in the Works. Now, an Investigation Looms." *New York Times*.

2. 9/1 Voter attitudes and behaviors
   (a) What do voters think about these goods?
   (b) How do voters act to get what they want?

   - Hankinson, Michael. 2018. "When do renters behave like homeowners? High rent, price anxiety, and NIMBYism." *American Political Science Review* 112(3), pp.473-493.
   - Broockman, David, Christopher S. Elmendorf, and Joshua Kalla. "The Symbolic Politics of Housing." Forthcoming at *American Political Science Review*.
   - Roberts, David. 2023. "What rural people actually think about clean energy." *Volts*. `https://www.volts.wtf/p/what-rural-people-actually-think`
   - Einstein, Katherine Levine, Maxwell Palmer, and David M. Glick. 2019. "Who participates in local government? Evidence from meeting minutes." *Perspectives on Politics* 17(1): 28-46.

   Supplemental reading

   - Been, Vicki, Ingrid Gould Ellen, and O'Regan, Katherine., 2019. "Supply Skepticism: Housing Supply and Affordability." *Housing Policy Debate* 29(1): 25-40.
   - Been, Vicki, Ingrid Gould Ellen, and Katherine O'Regan. 2025. "Supply Skepticism Revisited." *Housing Policy Debate* 35(1): 96-113.
   - Elmendorf, Christopher S., Clayton Nall, and Stan Oklobdzija. 2025. "The Folk Economics of Housing." *Journal of Economic Perspectives* 39(3): 45-66.

3. 9/8 In the defense of localism
   (a) What does localism allow that is less available at other levels of government?
   (b) What are the limits of localism?

   - Dunkelman. 2025. Introduction & Chapter 1.
   - Fung, Archon, 2006. "Varieties of Participation in Complex Governance." *Public Administration Review* 66: 66-75.
   - Schragger, Richard C., 2021. "The Perils of Land Use Deregulation." *University of Pennsylvania Law Review* 125-205.

   Supplemental reading

   - Tiebout, Charles M. 1956. "A Pure Theory of Local Expenditures." *Journal of Political Economy* 64(5), pp.416-424.
   - Fischel, William. 2015 *Zoning Rules!* Chapter 5.
   - deBoer, Freddie. 2025. "The Misunderstood Urban NIMBY." *The Vital City*.

4. 9/15 What's fair?
   (a) What is equity in the context of infrastructure development?
   (b) How are these goods distributed?
   (c) Do voters care about equity?

   - Dunkelman. 2025. Chapter 2.

- Jenkins, K., McCauley, D., Heffron, R., Stephan, H. and Rehner, R., 2016. Energy justice: A conceptual review. Energy research & social science, 11, pp.174-182.
- Pulido, Laura. 2000. "Rethinking environmental racism: White privilege and urban development in Southern California." *Annals of the association of American Geographers* 90(1), pp.12-40.
- Been, Vicki, 1993. "What's fairness got to do with it? Environmental justice and the siting of locally undesirable land uses." *Cornell Law Review* 78: 1001.

Supplemental reading

- Mohai, Paul and Saha, Robin, 2015. "Which came first, people or pollution? Assessing the disparate siting and post-siting demographic change hypotheses of environmental injustice." *Environmental Research Letters* 10(11), p.115008.
- Levine, Jeremy. 2021. *Constructing Community*. Princeton University Press. pp. 163-191.
- Schlosberg, David. 2004. "Reconceiving Environmental Justice: Global Movements and Political Theories." *Environmental Politics*.
- Goetz, Edward G., Rashad A. Williams, and Anthony Damiano. 2020. "Whiteness and Urban Planning." *Journal of the American Planning Association* 86(2): 142-156.

5. 9/22 Persuasion

   (a) Can voters be persuaded to support more infrastructure?

   (b) Can a fairer process legitimize unpopular outcomes?

   (c) Can compensation build fair deals?

- Dunkelman. 2025. Chapter 3.
- Hankinson, Michael. 2025. "The Resilient Effect of Process on Perceived Fairness and Legitimacy in Wind Energy Siting." Working paper.
- Robert, David. 2023. "Getting local communities on board with renewable energy, Australia edition." *Volts*. `https://www.volts.wtf/p/getting-local-communities-on-board`.
- Gaffney, Austin. "This Vermont town embraced a wind farm. Solar is a different story." *Megaprojects*.
- Adelman, David E. 2025. "Overcoming The Economic and Legal Barriers to Local Acceptance of Renewable Energy Projects." Working paper.

Supplemental reading

- Broockman, D.E., Elmendorf, C.S. and Kalla, J.L., 2026. How Sociotropic Aesthetic Judgments Drive Opposition to Dense Housing Development.
- Wolsink, Maarten. 2007. "Wind Power Implementation: The Nature of Public Attitudes: Equity and Fairness Instead of 'Backyard Motives'." *Renewable and Sustainable Energy Reviews* 11(6): 1188-1207.

9/29 No class, Prof. Hankinson travel.

6. 10/6 Decision-makers and their decisions

   (a) What shapes legislator decision-making?

   (b) Are elected officials aware of public preferences when it comes to infrastructure?

   (c) How have party organizations responded to these issues?

- Dunkelman. 2025. Chapter 4.

- Hankinson, Michael and Magazinnik, Asya. 2023. "The supply-equity trade-off: The effect of spatial representation on the local housing supply." *The Journal of Politics*. 85(3), pp.1033-1047.
- Hankinson, Michael and Adrian Pietrzak. "City Limited Responsiveness." Working paper.
- Stokes, Leah and Lomov, D., 2026. "Electoral Returns from Climate Policy: The Effect of the Inflation Reduction Act's Manufacturing Investments." Working paper.

Supplemental reading

- Chou, Winston, and Rafaela Dancygier. 2021. "Why Parties Displace Their Voters: Gentrification, Coalitional Change, and the Demise of Public Housing." *American Political Science Review* 115(2): 429-449.
- Liu, M., 2026. The varied impact of direct democracy on local housing policies: unravelling the role of socioeconomic context. Local Government Studies, 52(2), pp.313-345.
- de Benedictis-Kessner, Justin, Daniel Jones, and Christopher Warshaw. Forthcoming. "How Partisanship in Cities Influences Housing Policy." *American Journal of Political Science*.

10/13 No class, Fall Break.

7. 10/20 State preemption
   (a) When do state legislatures preempt local control?
   (b) How do voters respond to state preemption?

- Dunkelman. 2025. Chapter 5.
- Elmendorf, Christopher S., Clayton Nall, and Stan Oklobdzija. 2024. "What State Housing Policies Do Voters Want? Evidence from a Platform-Choice Experiment." Journal of Political Institutions and Political Economy 5(1): 117–152.
- Stokes, Leah C. 2016. "Electoral Backlash Against Climate Policy: A Natural Experiment on Retrospective Voting and Local Resistance to Public Policy." *American Journal of Political Science* 60(4): 958-974.
- Anderson, S.R. and Johnson, M.F., 2024. "The spatial and scalar politics of a just energy transition in Illinois." *Political Geography* 112, p.103128.

Supplemental reading

   (a) Briffault, Richard. 2018. "The Challenge of the New Preemption." *Stanford Law Review*. 70: 1995.
   (b) Honig, Jesse. 2023. "Local Restrictions on Renewable Energy Siting in the United States." *Hastings Law Journal*.
   (c) Gulbrandsen. "The limitations of the one-stop-shop approach: How local experiences shaped opposition to the Norwegian wind power permitting system"

8. 10/27 Federal policy
   (a) What tools does the federal government have to incentivize local governments?
   (b) Are there powers of federal preemption?
   (c) What are the federal politics of limiting opposition?

- Dunkelman. 2025. Chapter 6.
- Liscow, Zachary. 2025. "Getting infrastructure built: the law and economics of permitting." *Journal of Economic Perspectives* 39(1), pp.151-180.

- Adelman, David E., Sommer Engels, Andrew Mergen, and Jamie Pleune. 2025. "Dispelling the Myths of Permitting Reform and Identifying Effective Pathways Forward." *Env't L. Rep.* 55: 10038.
- Brown, Hannah S.. 2026. "NEPA and its Discontents" *The American Prospect*.
- https://blogs.law.columbia.edu/climatechange/2025/07/02/seven-county-infrastructure-coalition-the-supreme-courts-substantial-deference-standard-and-implications-for-judicial-review-under-nepa/

Supplemental reading

- Kayla Race. 2020. "Measuring the NEPA Litigation Burden: A Review of 1,499 Federal Court Cases." Environmental Law 50(2): 479.
- Rossi, Jim. 2009. "The Trojan Horse of Electric Power Transmission Line Siting Authority." *Environmental Law* 39: 1015.

9. 11/3 Peer review I
    - 5 of your peers' essay submissions
10. 11/10 Peer review II
    - 5 of your peers' essay submissions
11. 11/17 Peer review III
    - 5 of your peers' essay submissions

11/24 No class, Thanksgiving holiday.

12. 12/1 Case studies in housing and community goods
    (a) What are the most promising opportunities for housing reform?
    (b) What are the biggest unanswered questions in the politics of housing?
    - Dunkelman. 2025. Chapter 7.
    - Other readings to be finalized based on policy debates at the time.
13. 12/8 Case studies in energy and data centers
    (a) What are the most promising opportunities for energy reform?
    (b) What are the biggest unanswered questions in the politics of energy?
    (c) How do the demands of AI reshape energy politics?
    - Dunkelman. 2025. Chapter 8 & Conclusion.
    - Son, Jasmine. 2026. "no data centers in my backyard." Substack.
    - Other readings to be finalized based on policy debates at the time.

AI Policy

You may use AI as you see fit on work outside of class hours. You are responsible for any mistakes made by AI generation. This includes plagiarism, factual inaccuracies, or fabricated sources. Each fabrication will result in a 25 point penalty on the assignment

University Policies

Observance of Religious Holidays

Students must notify faculty during the first week of the semester in which they are enrolled in the course, or as early as possible, but no later than three weeks prior to the absence, of their intention to be absent from class on their day(s) of religious observance. If the holiday falls within the first three weeks of class, the student must inform faculty in the first week of the semester. For details and policy, see: `provost.gwu.edu/policies-procedures-and-guidelines`.

Academic Integrity Code

Academic integrity is an essential part of the educational process, and all members of the GW community take these matters very seriously. As the instructor of record for this course, my role is to provide clear expectations and uphold them in all assessments. Violations of academic integrity occur when students fail to cite research sources properly, engage in unauthorized collaboration, falsify data, and otherwise violate the Code of Academic Integrity. If you have any questions about whether particular academic practices or resources are permitted, you should ask me for clarification. If you are reported for an academic integrity violation, you should contact Conflict Education and Student Accountability (CESA), formerly known as Student Rights and Responsibilities (SRR), to learn more about your rights and options in the process. Consequences can range from failure of assignment to expulsion from the University and may include a transcript notation. For more information, refer to the CESA website at students.gwu.edu/code-academic-integrity or contact CESA by email cesa@gwu.edu or phone 202-994-6757.

Use of Electronic Course Materials and Class Recordings

Students are encouraged to use electronic course materials, including recorded class sessions, for private personal use in connection with their academic program of study. Electronic course materials and recorded class sessions should not be shared or used for non-course related purposes unless express permission has been granted by the instructor. Students who impermissibly share any electronic course materials are subject to discipline under the Student Code of Conduct. Contact the instructor if you have questions regarding what constitutes permissible or impermissible use of electronic course materials and/or recorded class sessions. Contact Disability Support Services at disabilitysupport.gwu.edu if you have questions or need assistance in accessing electronic course materials.

Writing Center

GW's Writing Center cultivates confident writers in the University community by facilitating collaborative, critical, and inclusive conversations at all stages of the writing process. Working alongside peer mentors, writers develop strategies to write independently in academic and public settings. Appointments can be booked online. See `gwu.mywconline`.

Academic Commons

Academic Commons provides tutoring and other academic support resources to students in many courses. Students can schedule virtual one-on-one appointments or attend virtual drop-in sessions. Students may schedule an appointment, review the tutoring schedule, or access other academic support resources at `academiccommons.gwu.edu`. For assistance contact `academiccommons@gwu.edu`.

Disability Support Services (DSS)

Any student who may need an accommodation based on the potential impact of a disability should contact Disability Support Services to establish eligibility and to coordinate reasonable accommodations: `disabilitysupport.gwu.edu` or call 202-994-8250.

Student Health Center

The Student Health Center (SHC) offers medical, counseling/psychological, and psychiatric services to GW students. More information about the SHC is available at healthcenter.gwu.edu. Students experiencing a medical or mental health emergency on campus should contact GW Emergency Services at 202-994-6111, or off campus at 911.

Safety and Security

- In an emergency: call GWPD 202-994-6111 or 911
- For situation-specific actions: review the Emergency Response Handbook at `safety.gwu.edu/emergency-response-handbook`
- GW Alert is an emergency notification system that sends alerts to the GW community. GW requests students, faculty, and staff maintain current contact information by logging on to `alert.gwu.edu`. Alerts are sent via email, text, social media, and other means, including the Guardian app. The Guardian app is a safety app that allows you to communicate quickly with GW Emergency Services, 911, and other resources. Learn more at `safety.gwu.edu`.
- Protective Actions - GW prescribes four protective actions that can be issued by university officials depending on the type of emergency. All GW community members are expected to follow directions according to the specified protective action. The protective actions are Shelter, Evacuate, Secure, and Lockdown (details below). Learn more at `safety.gwu.edu/gw-standard-emergency-statuses`.
- Classroom emergency lockdown buttons - Some classrooms have been equipped with classroom emergency lockdown buttons. If the button is pushed, GWorld Card access to the room will be disabled, and GW Dispatch will be alerted. The door must be manually closed if it is not closed when the button is pushed. Anyone in the classroom will be able to exit, but no one will be able to get in.